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Franklin & Marshall College Poll: August 2026

Summary of Findings

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Table of Contents

Key Findings 3
Detailed Findings 4
Direction of State and Personal Finances 4
State Politics 6
Presidential Ratings 7
Methodology 10
Questions from the Public about our Polling 11
Table A-1: Personal Finances 15
Table A-2: Gubernatorial Performance 16
Table A-3: Presidential Performance 17
Table A-4: President Trump's Performance: Dealing with Inflation 18
Table A-5: Ratings of Trump Policy Effects 19

Key Findings

The August 2026 Franklin & Marshall College Poll finds that Pennsylvania's registered voters are deeply concerned about their personal finances, experiencing significant economic stress, and increasingly dissatisfied with President Trump's performance. Voters say the economy (31%) is the most important problem facing the state. Among those who mention economic problems, Democrats lead Republicans as the party that can best handle the issue, 47% to 23%, which is a larger advantage for Democrats than in June when it was 42% to 24%. The economy is the top concern of every partisan group. Nearly half (44%) of respondents say they are "worse off" financially than a year ago. Economic pessimism and concern about the economy is a direct result of the difficulties the state's registered voters have paying for necessities. For example, more than half of the state's voters say it is "very difficult" or "somewhat difficult" to pay their utility bills (57%) or to pay for groceries (55%).

Governor Shapiro's job approval ratings are holding up well considering how much pessimism voters express. About the same number of voters believe he is doing an "excellent" or "good" job (47%) as governor as believe he is doing a "fair" or "poor" job (47%). The race for governor has changed little since June, with Governor Shapiro leading his Republican challenger, Stacy Garrity, 50% to 25% in the 2026 governor's race.

Fewer voters believe President Trump is doing an "excellent" or "good" job (27%) as president than believe he is doing a "fair" or "poor" job (73%), which is a sizable decline since our October poll when his positive approval rating was 41%. The president's approval ratings for his specific policy actions around immigration, foreign affairs, and inflation have all declined since October. Only one in three (33%) registered voters believes that the president's policies have helped them personally.

Detailed Findings

Direction of State and Personal Finances

More registered voters believe the state is "on the wrong track" (45%) than believe it is "headed in the right direction" (41%). The last time a majority of registered voters believed the state was headed in the right direction was January 2020. Nearly half (44%) of respondents say they are "worse off" financially than a year ago, an increase from two in five (36%) respondents in the March 2026 F&M Poll and similar to the June poll (47%). About half of Democrats and independent voters say they are "worse off" financially than last year, as do 31% of Republicans (see Table A-1). More voters expect to be "worse off" financially next year (32%) than expect to be "better off" (20%), which is a much more pessimistic assessment than in March, prior to the war with Iran, and similar to June. Voters have been more pessimistic than optimistic about their personal financial circumstances since October 2020 (see Figure 1).

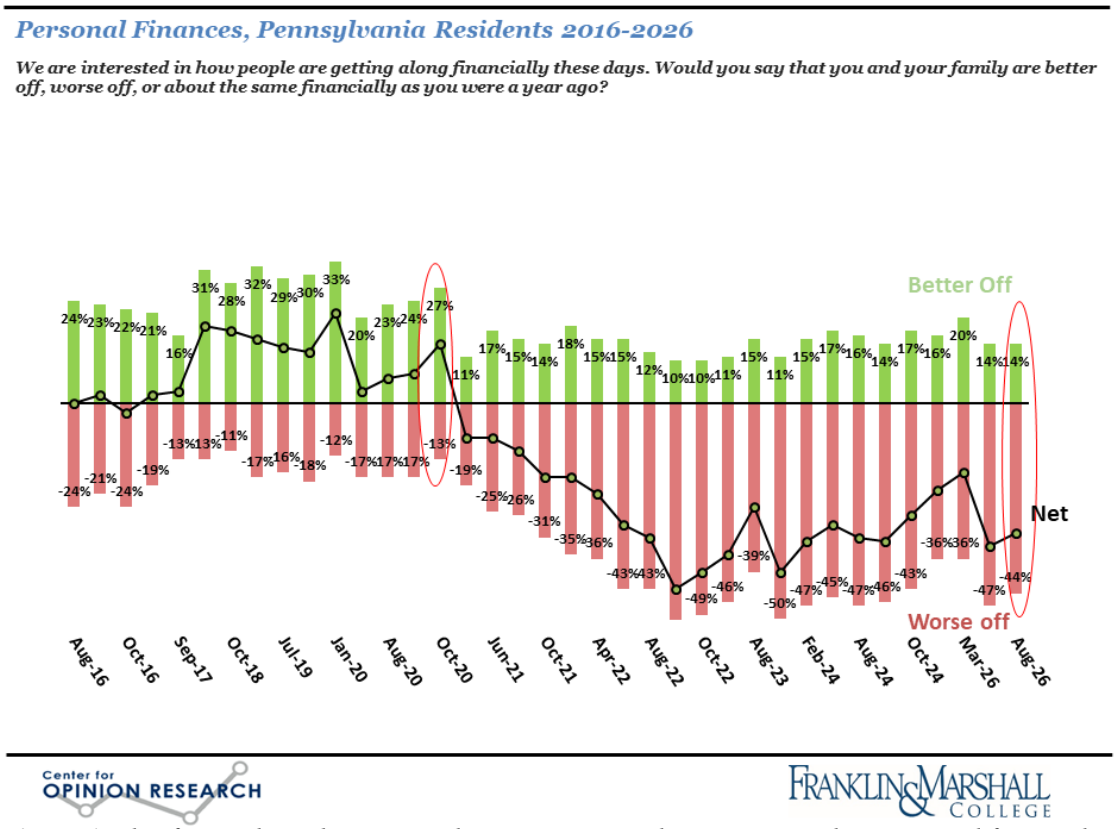


Figure 1. *This figure shows how Pennsylvania's registered voters assess their personal financial circumstances.*

Voters report that the economy (31%), including unemployment, housing and real estate costs, and higher gas and utility prices, is the most important problem facing the state. The economy is the top concern of every partisan group (Democrats (34%), independents (22%), Republicans (29%)). Concern about government and politics (12%), the top concern last October, is mentioned less often than the economy as the top problem. Among those who mention economic problems, Democrats lead Republicans as the party that can best handle the issue, 47% to 23%, which is a larger advantage for Democrats than in June when it was 42% to 24%.

Concern about the economy and the associated economic pessimism comes from the difficulties the state's registered voters say they have paying for necessities. More than half of the state's registered voters say it is "very difficult" or "somewhat difficult" to pay their utility bills (57%), to pay for groceries (55%), or to pay for entertainment and recreation (55%) (see Figure 2). Nearly four in five voters had at least some difficulty paying for one or more of these expenses, with sizable numbers of voters in all partisan groups, Republican (74%), Democrat (79%), and independent (71%), saying they had some difficulty paying for at least one of six listed expenses.

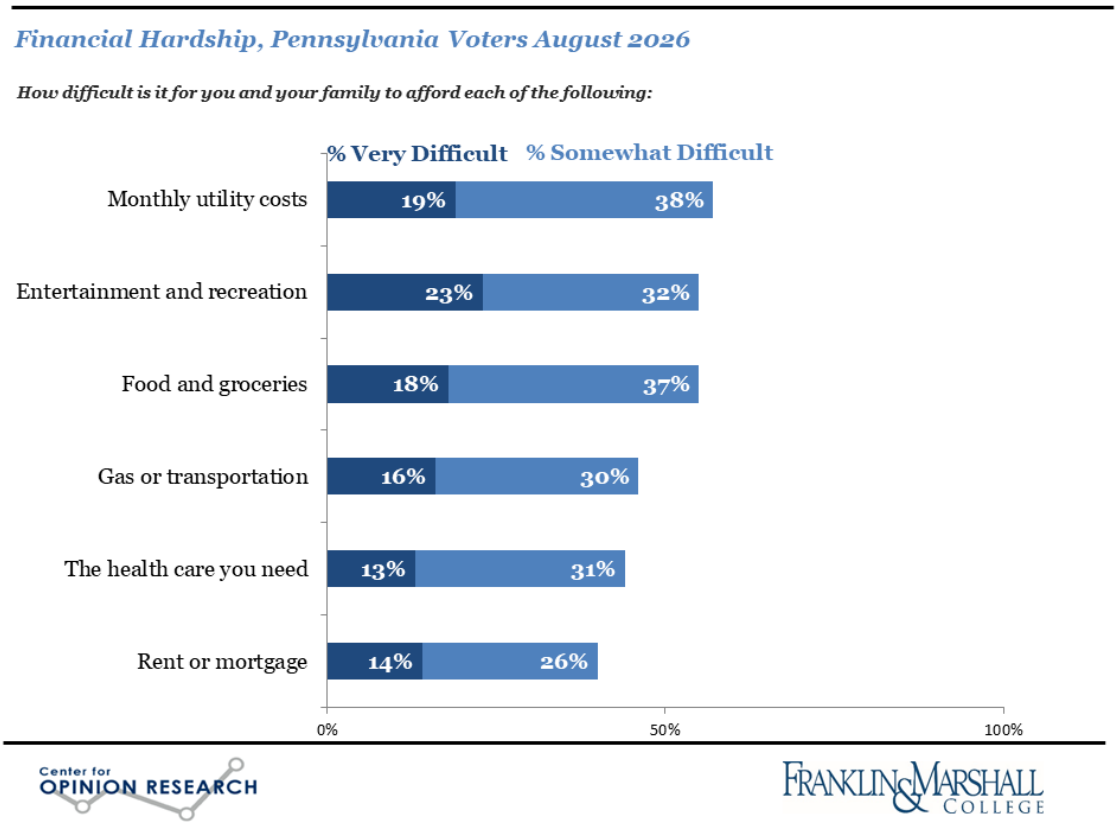


Figure 2. *This figure shows how many Pennsylvania registered voters are having difficulty paying for each type of household expense.*

State Politics

Governor Shapiro's job approval ratings are holding up pretty well considering how much pessimism voters express. About the same number of voters believes he is doing an "excellent" or "good" job (47%) as governor as believes he is doing a "fair" or "poor" job (47%). Seven in ten Democrats, almost half of independents, and just under a quarter of Republicans rates the governor's performance as "excellent" or "good" (see Table A-2). Governor Shapiro currently leads his Republican challenger, Stacy Garrity, 50% to 25% in the 2026 governor's race, which is consistent with the lead he held in June (50% to 28%).

The survey included questions about artificial intelligence, data centers, and technology

and found that:

- More than four in five (84%) voters believes artificial intelligence companies should be more closely regulated by the federal government.
- Four in five (79%) opposes having a data center built in their community.
- More registered voters are "nervous" (76%) than "excited" (19%) about recent developments in artificial intelligence.
- Twice as many registered voters believe that technological changes like smartphones, social media, and artificial intelligence are more negative (66%) than positive (31%) for society.

Presidential Ratings

Fewer voters believe President Trump is doing an "excellent" or "good" job (27%) as president than believe he is doing a "fair" or "poor" job (73%), which is a sizable decline since our March poll when his positive approval rating was 39%. If President Trump's net approval rating does not rise, his party will enter the midterms with lower presidential approval than any of his predecessors, including his ratings during his first midterm election in 2018 (see Figure 3). About three in five Republicans, one in six independents, and only one in twenty Democrats rate the president's job performance as "excellent" or "good" (see Table A-3). President Trump's positive approval rating among white voters without a college degree (31%) has been declining and is now lower than Governor Shapiro's rating (41%) among this group. Democrats currently lead Republicans by 12 points, 48% to 36%, in their preferences for the US House of Representatives.

The president's approval ratings for his specific policy actions around immigration, foreign affairs, and inflation have declined slightly since June but sizably since October. The Trump administration ratings for dealing with immigration slid from 47% "excellent" or "very good" in

October to 38% now. The administration's rating for handling foreign policy matters has declined from 42% to 26%. His largest proportional decline is for his administration's handling of inflation, falling from 31% positive in October to 15% today. Only one in three (33%) registered voters believes that the president's policies have helped them personally, including only one in four (23%) independent voters (see Table A-5).

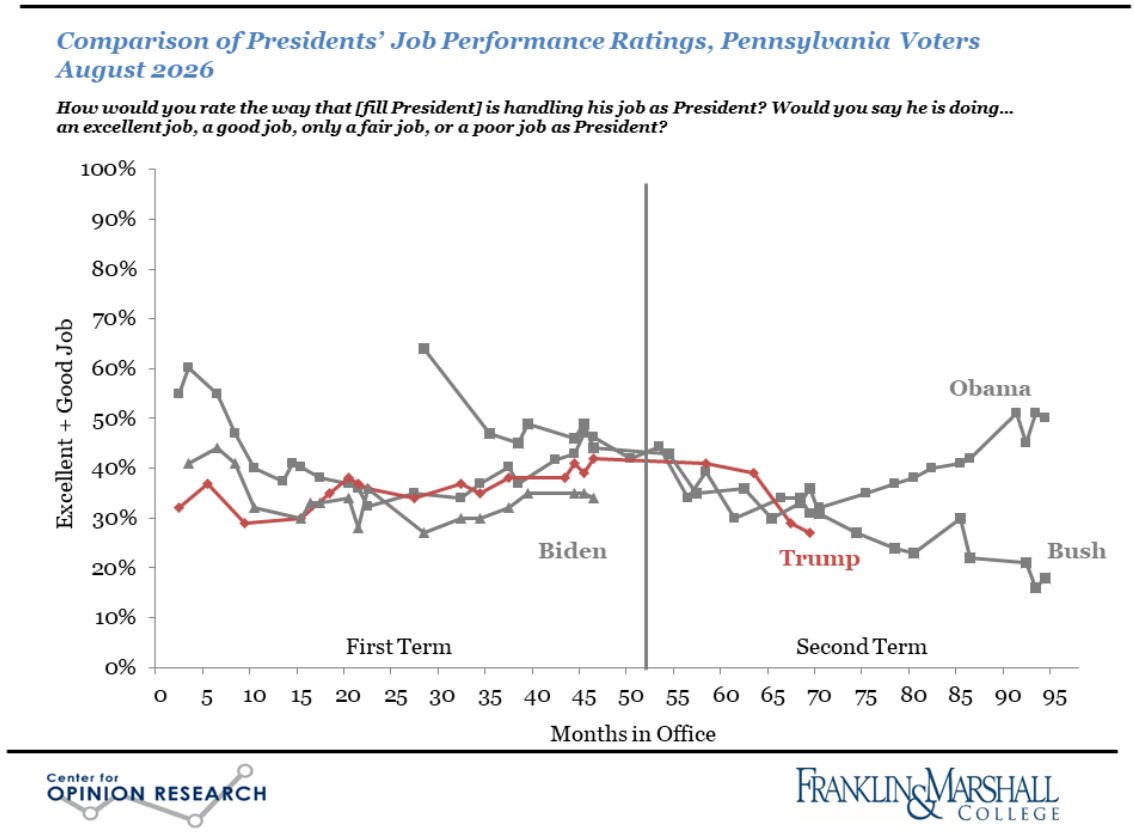


Figure 3. *This figure shows approval ratings among Pennsylvania registered voters for recent presidents in relation to their months in office.*

Table 1 shows a set of political indicators for recent presidents that provide a useful framework for thinking about the upcoming midterm races. These indicators show that Democrats are in a relatively strong political position at the moment, with President Trump's approval ratings being among the lowest of any recent president and having a sizable advantage on the generic ballot question. Democrats (61%) are currently more likely than Republicans (51%) to say they are "very interested" in the upcoming elections.

Table 1. Selected Political Midterm Indicators, Pennsylvania

	Oct 2006	Oct 2010	Oct 2014	Oct 2018	Oct 2022	Aug 2026
Pennsylvania headed in right direction	47%	27%	28%	51%	28%	41%
Most important problem	--	Economy	Education	Government Education Economy	Economy Government Crime	Economy Government
Presidential job approval rating	Bush:	Obama:	Obama:	Trump	Biden	Trump
(% excellent + good)	31%	32%	32%	36%	36%	27%
Generic ballot *(Democrat candidate % - Republican candidate %)*	--	+4 R	+ 6 D	+15 D	+5 R	+12 D
Party Identification *(Democrat ID % - Republican ID %)*	+5 D	+2 R	+6 D	+11 D	+ 4 R	+ 8 D
Party Control (seat changes in PA)						
US House	D (+4)	R (+5)	R (0)	E (D + 4)	D (R -1)	
State House	D (+9)	R (+13)	R (+ 9)	R (D +11)	D (+ 9)	
State Senate	R (D +1)	R (0)	R (+3)	R (D +5)	R (D +1)	

Methodology

The survey findings presented in this release are based on the results of interviews conducted August 17 - 23, 2026. The interviews were conducted at the Center for Opinion Research at Franklin & Marshall College. The data included in this release represent the responses of 501 registered Pennsylvania voters, including 213 Democrats, 208 Republicans, and 80 independents.[1] The sample of voters was obtained from Aristotle. All sampled respondents were notified by mail about the survey. Interviews were completed over the phone and online depending on each respondent's preference. Survey results were weighted (age, gender, education, geography, vote history, and party registration) using an iterative weighting algorithm to reflect the known distribution of those characteristics. Estimates for age, geography, and party registration are based on active voters within the Pennsylvania Department of State's voter registration data. Gender and education are estimated using data from the November 2022 CPS Voter Registration Supplement.

The sample error for this survey is +/- 5.5 percentage points when the design effects from weighting are considered. The sample error for questions based on subgroups is larger. An alternative means of calculating the variation in a sample is to take a series of bootstrap samples from the original sample and to use those bootstrapped samples to produce an estimate of sampling error. The procedure involves resampling a data set, calculating a statistic for each bootstrapped sample, accumulating the results of these samples, and calculating a sample distribution. The standard deviation of the mean of 10,000 bootstrapped samples for President Trump's positive job approval ratings was 2.0%, and 95% of the samples fell within a range of

[1] The data reported here is voter REGISTRATION and is consistent with past reporting practices. The survey also asked about self-reported voter IDENTIFICATION, which shows a slightly different partisan split: 38% identify as Republican (n=188), 12% as independent (n=58), 46% as Democrat (n=219) and the balance not offering a response. Partisan comparisons in this summary show self-reported registration.

23% and 31%.

In addition to sampling error, this poll is also subject to other sources of non-sampling error. Generally speaking, two sources of error concern researchers most. Non-response bias is created when selected participants either choose not to participate in the survey or are unavailable for interviewing. Response errors are the product of the question and answer process. Surveys that rely on self-reported behaviors and attitudes are susceptible to biases related to the way respondents process and respond to survey questions.

Note: This poll was supported by a gift from Franklin & Marshall College Alumnus Brett Harwood, Class of '71.

Questions from the Public about our Polling

Q: Do you require your final sample to have specific numbers of people in certain groups, for example, do you use quotas for age, party, or region?

- The Franklin & Marshall College Poll does not use quotas, meaning we do not specify ahead of time how many people from each group is in our sample, although we may do more non-response outreach with groups that are underrepresented in our pool of completes.

Q: What proportion of interviews are conducted by calling cellphones? What are the overall percentages who completed the survey online and by phone?

- The Franklin & Marshall College Poll uses a mixed mode approach, which means that a person can respond over the telephone or online. One-fifth (n=99) of the completed interviews in this poll were completed over the phone. All of the telephone completes were identified as cell phones.

Q: Many people complete your surveys online. What measures do you take to make sure they are attentive and real people, not bots?

- We review the responses of every survey participant and compute an attentiveness score for each completed interview, whether completed online or on the telephone. For this survey, attentiveness scoring includes measuring the amount of time the respondent spent in the main body of the survey questionnaire, coding the quality of open-ended responses (did the response relate to the question, was it clear, was it coherent); and computing the total number of missing and don't know responses.

Q: Do you send any additional mailers or do other reminders to people who don't respond to your postcard invitation? How does non-response affect your surveys?

- The Franklin & Marshall College Poll's outreach to our sample always begins with a postcard mailer. Follow up outreach includes phone calls, emails, and text messages wherever that information is available. We will do up to four phone calls, two texts, and two emails (emails are not available for all respondents). Every respondent in our sample receives a unique ID they must use to complete a survey. We also do some non-response assessment from time to time so that people who care about that can see it (for example, here is an assessment of our 2022 polling), and we always calculate bootstrapped sample error estimates in addition to the traditional estimates.

Q: How do you handle the "someone else" and "do not know" responses for respondents taking the survey online?

- "Other" and "do not know" options appear on screen for the online surveys. "Do not know" is not read to phone participants and isn't included in the online question text but is accepted when offered.

Q: What is Aristotle and what gives you confidence that you have a representative sample?

- The way the Franklin & Marshall College Poll is conducted is sound because we follow best practices in our industry. We draw a random sample of voters from Aristotle, which is a company that many pollsters use to provide their samples (you can read more about them here). We then send a postcard to everyone in our sample letting them know we will be calling them, after which we follow up with phone calls, text messages, and emails depending on what kind of contact information is included for each voter. Survey participants can do the survey over the telephone or complete it online based on whichever method is more convenient. So we feel confident in the way we gather our data because we encourage participation and offer people lots of opportunities to participate.

Q: What's going on with party identification in your samples? In your subsets it seems like you oversampled Democrats.

- The question about party identification is important. Pennsylvania is one of those states where you need to be registered in a party at least 15 days prior to an election to vote and most voters in the state are registered as either Republicans or Democrats. You can get voter registration figures from the state's web site, which is here. If you go to that page and download the statistics, you will find that 42% of the state's active voters are registered as Democrats, 42% are registered as Republicans, and the rest (16%) are registered with a third party. If you compare the party breakdown in our samples you'll find that it matches those figures exactly, so we have the right partisan balance within our data. We write a lot about partisanship in the state (a list of some of those articles is here). It is worth noting that party registration, which we report, is not necessarily the same as party identification, something explained here.

Q: Many states' polls show different issues being most important to voters, why are your results different?

- There are many ways to ask about issues. Our approach is simply to ask a question at the beginning of the survey about the most important problem facing the state today. Survey participants can say whatever comes to mind, after which we put their responses into categories. In this and other recent polls, the economy, education, and politicians are at the top of the list. Other pollsters give people lists of issues and ask people to rate each one or to select one issue from their list; it is often these formats that produce responses that differ from ours. We are not suggesting that one approach is better than the other, just that they tend to produce different results.

Table A-1: Personal Finances

Pennsylvania registered voters, August 2026

We are interested in how people are getting along financially these days. Would you say that you and your family are better off, worse off, or about the same financially as you were a year ago?

	Better off	Worse off	About the same
Party*			
Republican	20%	31%	47%
Democrat	13%	52%	35%
Independent or something else	7%	48%	43%
Ideology*			
Liberal	11%	57%	33%
Moderate	11%	46%	42%
Conservative	23%	30%	46%
Gender			
Female	14%	47%	39%
Male	14%	42%	42%
Age			
Under 35	9%	50%	38%
35-54	18%	47%	35%
Over 55	14%	40%	46%
Education			
HS or less	14%	42%	43%
Some college	9%	48%	42%
College degree	18%	43%	39%
Race			
White	14%	45%	41%
Nonwhite	20%	33%	47%
Race & Education, White Voters			
White, No College Degree	11%	45%	43%
White, College Degree	17%	45%	38%
Income*			
Under $35,000	0%	78%	18%
$35,000-$75,000	7%	48%	44%
Over $75,000	21%	38%	41%
"Born-again" or evangelical Christian**			
Yes	28%	35%	37%
No	12%	44%	43%
Region*			
Philadelphia & Southeast	20%	46%	34%
Northeast	4%	42%	54%
Allegheny & Southwest	9%	40%	47%
Northwest	11%	50%	39%
Central	16%	45%	38%
Urban-Rural Classification			
Large Central Metro	8%	49%	41%
Large Fringe Metro	23%	41%	35%
Medium Metro	12%	44%	43%
Small Metro	9%	55%	37%
Micropolitan	11%	45%	44%
Noncore	0%	38%	62%

* p<0.01 ** p<0.05

Table A-2: Gubernatorial Performance

Pennsylvania registered voters, August 2026

How would you rate the way that Josh Shapiro is handling his job as governor? Would you say he is doing an excellent job, a good job, only a fair job, or a poor job as governor?

	Excellent	Good	Fair	Poor	Do not know
Party*					
Republican	10%	13%	31%	40%	5%
Democrat	29%	40%	19%	7%	5%
Independent or something else	21%	24%	25%	23%	7%
Ideology*					
Liberal	32%	36%	22%	7%	3%
Moderate	24%	32%	24%	15%	4%
Conservative	7%	16%	28%	44%	4%
Gender					
Female	18%	29%	24%	24%	4%
Male	21%	25%	24%	22%	8%
Age*					
Under 35	14%	17%	36%	21%	12%
35-54	20%	36%	20%	19%	5%
Over 55	22%	25%	22%	27%	5%
Education*					
HS or less	14%	25%	19%	35%	7%
Some college	16%	25%	28%	25%	6%
College degree	24%	30%	23%	16%	7%
Race					
White	20%	28%	24%	22%	6%
Nonwhite	20%	23%	27%	20%	11%
Race & Education, White Voters*					
White, No College Degree	15%	26%	25%	29%	6%
White, College Degree	25%	31%	23%	15%	6%
Income*					
Under $35,000	18%	26%	7%	31%	18%
$35,000-$75,000	18%	31%	22%	27%	3%
Over $75,000	22%	27%	27%	18%	5%
"Born-again" or evangelical Christian*					
Yes	6%	18%	29%	43%	5%
No	24%	30%	23%	18%	5%
Region*					
Philadelphia & Southeast	24%	25%	29%	16%	5%
Northeast	22%	33%	20%	18%	8%
Allegheny & Southwest	16%	28%	12%	34%	10%
Northwest	25%	39%	11%	19%	6%
Central	14%	23%	32%	27%	5%
Urban-Rural Classification					
Large Central Metro	24%	25%	22%	14%	15%
Large Fringe Metro	23%	28%	26%	21%	2%
Medium Metro	18%	31%	23%	22%	7%
Small Metro	14%	38%	14%	29%	4%
Micropolitan	3%	16%	31%	44%	5%
Noncore	19%	2%	15%	64%	0%

* p<0.01 ** p<0.05

Table A-3: Presidential Performance

Pennsylvania registered voters, August 2026

How would you rate the way that Donald Trump is handling his job as president? Would you say he is doing an excellent job, a good job, only a fair job, or a poor job as president?

	Excellent	Good	Fair	Poor	Do not know
Party*					
Republican	29%	29%	21%	19%	1%
Democrat	2%	2%	4%	91%	0%
Independent or something else	10%	8%	16%	66%	0%
Ideology*					
Liberal	1%	0%	2%	97%	0%
Moderate	4%	9%	19%	67%	0%
Conservative	31%	32%	18%	18%	1%
Gender*					
Female	13%	15%	8%	64%	0%
Male	13%	13%	19%	53%	2%
Age					
Under 35	6%	6%	20%	63%	5%
35-54	8%	6%	14%	72%	0%
Over 55	19%	23%	11%	47%	0%
Education*					
HS or less	18%	15%	20%	47%	0%
Some college	11%	17%	14%	56%	1%
College degree	12%	11%	11%	65%	1%
Race					
White	13%	15%	14%	58%	1%
Nonwhite	10%	12%	8%	70%	0%
Race & Education, White Voters**					
White, No College Degree	14%	17%	17%	50%	1%
White, College Degree	11%	12%	10%	66%	1%
Income					
Under $35,000	10%	2%	12%	76%	0%
$35,000-$75,000	18%	14%	15%	53%	0%
Over $75,000	10%	15%	12%	61%	2%
"Born-again" or evangelical Christian*					
Yes	9%	12%	13%	66%	1%
No	2%	0%	13%	72%	14%
Region*					
Philadelphia & Southeast	10%	12%	10%	67%	0%
Northeast	6%	14%	8%	72%	0%
Allegheny & Southwest	18%	13%	13%	51%	5%
Northwest	13%	12%	19%	56%	0%
Central	16%	16%	19%	48%	0%
Urban-Rural Classification*					
Large Central Metro	6%	6%	5%	79%	5%
Large Fringe Metro	16%	17%	14%	53%	0%
Medium Metro	12%	13%	15%	59%	0%
Small Metro	19%	17%	9%	55%	0%
Micropolitan	18%	15%	25%	42%	0%
Noncore	25%	31%	23%	21%	0%

* p<0.01 ** p<0.05

Table A-4: President Trump's Performance: Dealing with Inflation

Pennsylvania registered voters, August 2026

The following is a list of problems and issues. For each one, indicate how well President Trump's administration has performed, using an A for excellent, B for very good, C for average, D for below average or F for failing. How well has President Trump's administration performed…Dealing with inflation?

	A=Excellent	B=Very good	C=Average	D=Below average	F=Failing	Do not know
Party*						
Republican	7%	27%	35%	14%	16%	0%
Democrat	0%	2%	4%	12%	80%	1%
Independent or something else	5%	5%	17%	19%	52%	2%
Ideology*						
Liberal	0%	0%	2%	11%	84%	2%
Moderate	2%	7%	16%	18%	58%	0%
Conservative	8%	24%	36%	12%	18%	1%
Gender*						
Female	4%	12%	17%	12%	55%	0%
Male	3%	11%	20%	17%	47%	2%
Age						
Under 35	2%	5%	18%	11%	61%	3%
35-54	3%	6%	9%	16%	66%	0%
Over 55	4%	18%	25%	15%	37%	1%
Education*						
HS or less	3%	18%	17%	15%	46%	1%
Some college	1%	12%	27%	12%	47%	2%
College degree	5%	9%	13%	16%	57%	0%
Race						
White	2%	13%	19%	14%	51%	0%
Nonwhite	8%	0%	18%	19%	55%	0%
Race & Education, White Voters**						
White, No College Degree	1%	16%	25%	14%	44%	1%
White, College Degree	4%	10%	13%	14%	60%	0%
Income						
Under $35,000	1%	5%	10%	16%	67%	0%
$35,000-$75,000	2%	8%	29%	9%	50%	2%
Over $75,000	3%	14%	14%	14%	55%	0%
"Born-again" or evangelical Christian*						
Yes	9%	27%	35%	8%	21%	0%
No	2%	9%	14%	14%	60%	0%
Region*						
Philadelphia & Southeast	3%	13%	10%	14%	59%	1%
Northeast	0%	0%	22%	17%	61%	0%
Allegheny & Southwest	7%	10%	24%	17%	42%	0%
Northwest	0%	9%	20%	16%	56%	0%
Central	4%	18%	23%	12%	42%	2%
Urban-Rural Classification*						
Large Central Metro	1%	3%	12%	14%	71%	0%
Large Fringe Metro	6%	16%	15%	17%	44%	1%
Medium Metro	2%	9%	20%	12%	56%	2%
Small Metro	5%	25%	15%	8%	47%	0%
Micropolitan	1%	18%	34%	21%	26%	0%
Noncore	11%	7%	45%	16%	21%	0%

* p<0.01 ** p<0.05

Table A-5: Ratings of Trump Policy Effects

Pennsylvania registered voters, August 2026

Would you say that the Trump Administration's policies have helped or hurt you personally?

	Helped a lot	Helped somewhat	Hurt somewhat	Hurt a lot	Do not know
Party*					
Republican	27%	43%	12%	10%	9%
Democrat	3%	2%	40%	54%	2%
Independent or something else	4%	19%	31%	36%	10%
Ideology*					
Liberal	0%	0%	32%	64%	4%
Moderate	6%	14%	40%	37%	2%
Conservative	25%	46%	8%	10%	11%
Gender**					
Female	12%	22%	25%	38%	3%
Male	12%	20%	29%	30%	9%
Age*					
Under 35	4%	18%	31%	38%	9%
35-54	10%	9%	32%	44%	5%
Over 55	16%	31%	22%	26%	5%
Education					
HS or less	13%	28%	29%	24%	6%
Some college	12%	24%	24%	35%	6%
College degree	11%	16%	28%	38%	6%
Race					
White	10%	22%	27%	34%	6%
Nonwhite	15%	14%	29%	36%	6%
Race & Education, White Voters**					
White, No College Degree	10%	28%	27%	28%	6%
White, College Degree	10%	16%	27%	41%	7%
Income					
Under $35,000	4%	19%	23%	55%	0%
$35,000-$75,000	7%	31%	27%	35%	0%
Over $75,000	10%	20%	30%	32%	8%
"Born-again" or evangelical Christian*					
Yes	25%	45%	15%	13%	2%
No	7%	17%	29%	41%	5%
Region*					
Philadelphia & Southeast	10%	18%	27%	43%	2%
Northeast	6%	8%	33%	49%	5%
Allegheny & Southwest	15%	24%	28%	24%	9%
Northwest	8%	29%	28%	27%	8%
Central	15%	27%	24%	26%	8%
Urban-Rural Classification*					
Large Central Metro	4%	7%	35%	46%	8%
Large Fringe Metro	18%	23%	23%	30%	5%
Medium Metro	10%	19%	31%	35%	4%
Small Metro	13%	24%	11%	47%	4%
Micropolitan	12%	41%	20%	16%	12%
Noncore	11%	53%	6%	15%	14%

* p<0.01 ** p<0.05